

Employee Onboarding & IT Access Management

A go-to-market and product strategy for a B2B SaaS company serving India's mid-market technology sector

THE STRATEGIC COMMITMENT

Build the single source of truth for who has access to which software — for Indian B2B SaaS companies of 200–1,000 employees facing global enterprise compliance demands. Every hire, role change, or exit updates every software account automatically, and audit-ready evidence comes as a natural byproduct.

KEY TERMS USED IN THIS DOCUMENT

SOC 2 and ISO 27001

Independent security audits that prove a company handles customer data responsibly. SOC 2 is what US enterprise buyers require before signing contracts; ISO 27001 is the international equivalent often required by UK and European enterprises. These are commercial requirements, not legal ones — enterprises refuse to do business with vendors who can't show compliance.

HRIS (HR Information System)

Software that manages employee records, payroll, leave, and attendance. The main HRIS products used in India are Keka, Darwinbox, Zoho People, and greyTHR.

Identity and Access Management (IAM)

The software category that controls who can use which systems inside an organization. Okta and JumpCloud are the well-known global examples.

Access provisioning

Creating accounts and granting permissions across the dozens of software tools an employee needs to do their job.

01 The Target Customer

I am targeting Indian B2B SaaS companies with all of the following traits:

- | | |
|--|---|
| 1 200 to 1,000 employees | 2 Series B funded or later (or equivalent revenue stage) |
| 3 A primarily India-based workforce | 4 Selling to US or EU enterprise customers |
| 5 Facing SOC 2 or ISO 27001 audits as a condition of those enterprise sales | |

Why this segment

At this size, a few things are happening at once. The company is hiring 10–50 people a month. It uses around 100 different software tools to run the business. And its biggest enterprise contracts now demand security audits to close and renew.

The IT team — usually three to ten people — has outgrown spreadsheets and Jira tickets for managing access, but isn't yet at the scale where enterprise-grade tools make economic sense. They

are stuck in the middle: provisioning manually, offboarding manually, and rebuilding access review spreadsheets every quarter for auditors.

Why not other sizes

Below 200 employees, hiring volume is too low to justify a dedicated tool. Companies that small can manage with spreadsheets, and Keka or Zoho People already serve them cheaply.

Above 1,000 employees, the company is locked into enterprise platforms like Darwinbox or Workday. Sales cycles take 12 to 18 months — the wrong fit for a first PM with no proof points yet.

The 200–1,000 employee band is the sweet spot. The problem is real, the budget exists, and the buying decision can happen in weeks, not years.

Why specifically tech companies

Because they use far more software tools than other industries, and that's where the pain compounds. A 500-person tech company uses around 96 software applications; a 1,000-person tech company uses 116. A non-tech company at the same size uses a fraction of that.

Every additional tool means another account to provision when someone joins, another to revoke when they leave, and another row to track in the quarterly audit spreadsheet. The number of tools multiplies every operational problem.

Why the compliance trigger matters

The compliance trigger holds the whole strategy together. SOC 2 isn't an Indian law — it's a commercial requirement. US enterprises won't sign contracts with Indian SaaS vendors who can't show it. No certificate, no deal.

And it's not a one-time event. SOC 2 Type 2 (the more rigorous version) is renewed every year, with access reviews every three months. The pressure never goes away — exactly the kind of recurring, non-negotiable pressure that justifies ongoing software spend rather than one-time purchases.

Who buys first

The initial buyer is the **Head of IT** or **IT Manager**. The **CISO** is the budget unlock when executive sign-off is needed.

Not the HR Head — Keka and Darwinbox already own that relationship. HR Heads won't buy "better onboarding" from a new vendor when their HRIS vendor promises the same thing on its roadmap. But a CIO (Chief Information Officer) will sign for something specific: "no orphan accounts, clean audit evidence, and automatic Day 1 access." That framing moves the spend from discretionary IT operations into the allocated compliance budget — which is bigger and harder to cut.

What's deliberately outside Phase 1

- **Large enterprises (1,000+ employees)** — already locked in by entrenched enterprise HCM vendors. Procurement cycles make these long, hard sales for a first PM with no proof points.

- **Startups under 200 employees** — hiring volume is too low, and existing HRIS players already serve them at low price points.
- **IT services firms** — their engineers work on client tech stacks, not their own. The integration surface is fundamentally different from product companies.
- **D2C consumer brands** — same IT pain as B2B SaaS, but no SOC 2 trigger because they sell to consumers, not enterprises.
- **Global Capability Centers (GCCs)** — India-based back offices of multinationals. Despite India hosting over 1,760 GCCs employing 1.9 million people, their HR and IT decisions are made at parent HQ in San Francisco or London, not India.

Each of these is a credible Year 2–3 expansion target. None belongs in Phase 1.

02 Why This Opportunity Matters

The opportunity is sizeable, the problem happens constantly, the pain is real and concrete, and willingness to pay is already proven by adjacent products in the same buyer's budget.

The market context

The Indian HR-tech market is over **\$1 billion** in annual revenue, growing at high single-digit percentages. The Indian identity and access management market is in the **hundreds of millions**, growing faster. Our product sits at the operational layer that connects these two — turning HR hire events into provisioned access into audit-ready evidence.

Several hundred Indian companies fit our profile today, and the number grows as the Indian SaaS ecosystem expands. A realistic 2–3 year target — even a small share of this segment — is a credible Series A milestone. The long-term durability of the business comes from how it expands inside customers and how hard it becomes to replace, not from the size of this initial wedge.

How often the problem happens

Take a typical 500-person Indian tech company. In a normal year, it goes through:

- Roughly **100–150 new hires** — each needing provisioning across ~100 tools
- Roughly **75–125 offboardings** — each requiring complete access revocation
- **50–150 internal role changes** — each requiring partial re-provisioning
- **4 quarterly access reviews** — across every employee, every tool

Annual attrition in Indian tech runs 15–25%, which means roughly half the company turns over every four to five years. This isn't an occasional tool — it's a daily-to-weekly workflow, which is what makes the access graph a constantly refreshing data resource for the product.

How painful it is

The pain has three concrete layers.

1 · IT DRAG

48%

of IT teams worry about missing key offboarding steps. Each IT professional now supports 108 employees — a 31% workload jump in one year.

2 · DEAL RISK

₹Crores

at stake per delayed enterprise renewal. A failed access review or missed offboarding can stall or kill a contract.

3 · WASTE

53%

of software licenses go unused on average — money paid for access nobody is using.

IT operational drag. With ~100 software tools to provision per hire and revoke per exit, IT teams are doing high-volume manual work — logging into 30+ admin consoles for every new joiner, then the

same in reverse for every exit. This is a structural problem, not an incompetence problem.

Compliance cost and deal risk. Audit prep is expensive in consultant and audit fees, but the real cost is commercial: a failed access review or a missed offboarding can delay or kill an enterprise renewal. For a Series B+ Indian SaaS company, one delayed US enterprise deal is worth crores — a risk that dwarfs anything we'd plausibly charge.

Software license waste. If you don't know who has access to what, you also don't know which licenses are paid for but unused. This isn't the pain we lead with, but it becomes the foundation of the Finance expansion path later.

Why customers will pay

Sprinto is the clearest proof point. It's an Indian compliance automation company that solves a narrower piece of this problem — and it has over **1,000 customers** and has raised approximately **\$32 million**. Indian mid-market tech companies already pay ₹8-15 lakhs annually for tools that help with compliance.

Our product sits one layer below Sprinto in the workflow. Sprinto organizes evidence; we generate it — by automating the operational provisioning and offboarding work that the evidence depends on. That operational layer is where most of the actual labor sits today, so the willingness to pay extends there naturally.

The budget for our product already exists. It's just fragmented across HRIS, compliance tools, ticketing licenses, and significant manual IT effort. *We're not asking customers to find new budget — we're asking them to reallocate it.*

03 The Core Problem

Underneath every visible symptom — manual provisioning, incomplete offboarding, multi-week access reviews, fragmented compliance evidence — is a single root cause.

THE ROOT CAUSE

Indian mid-market tech companies have no single, authoritative record of who has access to what, when they got it, who approved it, and whether they still need it.

I call this the **employee access graph** — a complete, always-current map of every person, every tool, every permission, and every approval event. Today, in any of these companies, this map does not exist. The data lives in fragments: HRIS systems know who joined and when, Google Admin knows who has an email account, GitHub knows who can push code, Slack knows who is in which channel, and AWS, Jira, Notion, and Figma each know their own slice.

No tool knows the complete picture. No tool knows when any of it should change. The work of stitching this together happens through ticketing systems, spreadsheets, and institutional memory in the IT team's heads. This is not an IT operations problem — it is a missing data layer problem.

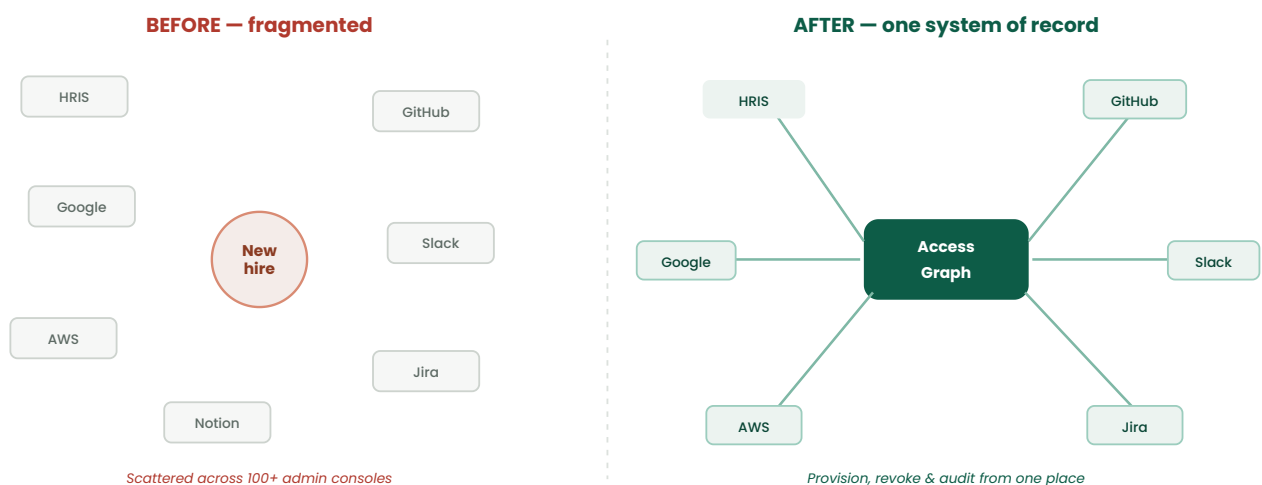


Figure 1 · From fragmented tool sprawl to a single, queryable access graph

How this single absence explains every symptom

Why provisioning is manual: there's no authoritative source saying “Priya, senior engineer, joined March 15, needs these 40 tools” and then pushing that automatically into action. Without it, IT recreates the context every time.

Why offboarding is incomplete: no one has the verified list of everything provisioned to a departing employee. Accounts get missed because no one remembers granting them.

Why access reviews take weeks: there's no unified, queryable record to ask "show me everyone with access to our production AWS environment as of today." So IT builds the record from scratch every quarter.

Why compliance evidence is fragmented: the underlying data lives in 15 different admin consoles, each with its own export format and user list.

Why compliance tools like Sprinto can't fix this: they collect evidence of the controls you have — they can't create the controls. If provisioning and offboarding are broken, the evidence built on top of them is broken too.

What solving this deeply means

Owning the access graph — making it the system of record for the entire employee access lifecycle. In practice: when HR marks a hire, the platform automatically provisions every tool the new employee needs; when someone leaves, revocation across every tool is complete and documented; when the quarterly access review comes around, it's a dashboard export, not a three-week spreadsheet project. That's the strategic commitment. The specific features that deliver it are implementation decisions, not strategy decisions.

What I'm not solving in Phase 1

- HR-side onboarding (culture, manager check-ins, performance setup)
- Payroll and benefits
- Laptop and device management

These are all real problems — just not where we start. The access graph we build in Year 1 is what makes all of them tractable later. Without it, each one is a separate product. With it, each becomes a natural extension.

04 Defensibility

A moat is anything that makes a product structurally harder to replace as it scales. Four moats apply to this product, building in the order described below.

1 Integration depth

Every integration we build is a permanent barrier to replication — a competitor wanting to serve our customers has to rebuild each one from scratch. The defensible core is the **Indian HRIS integrations**: Keka, Darwinbox, Zoho People, greytHR. These are India-specific systems with India-specific data — PF and ESIC compliance fields, CTC components (the way Indian salaries are split into fixed, variable, and benefits), gratuity tracking, and more. Global competitors haven't built these because their target market is US and global enterprise. Doing it correctly requires both technical engineering and domain knowledge of Indian HR — not insurmountable, but a real barrier they won't prioritize for Indian mid-market anytime soon. The broader library — Google Workspace, GitHub, Jira, Slack, AWS, Notion — takes time to build deeply, and is the core surface any competitor must match.

2 Switching costs

Once we become the system of record for the access graph, replacing us gets progressively harder. A customer who has configured dozens of integrations and built role-based access templates can't leave without restarting that work from zero. A customer with months or years of access history can't easily migrate that data — and SOC 2 audits require access history continuity, so leaving mid-audit-cycle introduces compliance risk. Over time, the platform accumulates a customer's role templates, approval chains, and access patterns calibrated to their specific organization. This institutional knowledge becomes part of the product itself. Unlike traditional SaaS lock-in, the stickiness here is reinforced by external compliance pressure — leaving has compliance risk attached, not just operational disruption.

3 Data

With scale, the product gets meaningfully smarter in ways a competitor can't replicate. Across many customers, we learn what tools a Series B Indian SaaS company with a platform engineering team typically provisions per role, with what approval chains, in what order — so new customers get templates calibrated to companies like theirs. We learn which tools are most often missed in manual offboarding and flag them automatically. We can benchmark a customer's access patterns against comparable companies. A competitor without our customer base can't generate this intelligence, no matter how well-funded — it's a function of operating data, not engineering effort.

4 Brand

No product currently owns the category of “IT lifecycle management for Indian mid-market tech companies.” Sprinto owns compliance automation, Keka owns HR, Darwinbox owns enterprise HCM. The space we’re entering has no incumbent owner in India. By being the first to define this category clearly — and earning a base of customers with strong outcomes — we become the default name when an IT Head asks peers what to use, when compliance consultants advise on tooling, when VC portfolio companies recommend tools across their investments. This is a brand moat earned over time, through category clarity and customer outcomes.

How the moats compound

These four moats reinforce each other. Together they’re harder to overcome than any one would be alone.

- **Integration depth** makes us the only viable choice for India-domestic mid-market today
- **Switching costs** lock in early customers as compliance evidence and configured workflows accumulate
- **Data** turns the product into something a competitor can’t replicate without an equivalent customer base
- **Brand** makes us the default name in a category we defined

The single asset that powers all four is the access graph itself. The integrations build it. The data fills it. The history makes it irreplaceable. The brand comes from being the company that owns it.

05 Land and Expand

“Land and expand” only works under three conditions:

- 1 **Switching costs build quickly after landing** — so customers stay during expansion.
- 2 **Each expansion is a natural extension of the core product** — not a separate product stapled on.
- 3 **Unit economics improve at scale** — not just discounts to win logos.

All three apply here. Switching costs build through the access graph as soon as the customer goes live. Every expansion module reads from that same graph rather than collecting new data. The integration library improves with each new customer, reducing the marginal cost of acquiring the next one.

The land

We enter with **automated provisioning for new hires**. When HR marks a hire in Keka or Darwinbox, the event propagates automatically and provisions every tool the new employee needs, with documented approvals and a complete access record from Day 1. This is the right wedge because it's the most frequent, recurring, immediately visible pain the buyer has; the before-and-after is binary (access on Day 1 or not); time-to-value is two to three weeks, not six months; and we're connecting existing tools rather than replacing them, so adoption risk is low.

The initial buyer is the **Head of IT**, managing a team of three to ten, whose week is dominated by ticket queues and whose company is in or near a SOC 2 audit cycle. The **CISO** is the budget unlock — the compliance frame turns the conversation from “IT productivity tool” into “audit-grade evidence infrastructure,” moving the spend into a larger budget category.

How internal pull is created

Once the product is running, the access graph makes employee access data visible across the organization in ways that surface unmet needs in other teams. This is how single-buyer landing turns into multi-stakeholder expansion:

- **HR** sees the structured provisioning workflow and realizes they could use the same platform for their side of onboarding — policy acknowledgments, welcome communications, role clarity, manager introductions. They weren't the initial buyer; they become the next one.
- **The CISO** sees the first complete, timestamped offboarding audit trail and realizes the same data structure could replace their quarterly access review spreadsheet. They go from approver to active user.
- **Finance** eventually sees that the access graph knows who has access to which tools and how often they use them, and starts asking which licenses are paid for but unused. That's a CFO conversation worth having.

The pull doesn't come from us pushing modules. It comes from the data being visible. Once people see what's possible, they ask for it.



Figure 2 · One landing in IT compounds into HR, Security, and Finance — all reading from the same access graph

Expansion triggers

- 1 **The first complete offboarding.** It produces an audit trail visibly better than anything the customer had before. The CISO sees it and asks to extend into compliance reporting. This is the fastest and most reliable expansion trigger.
- 2 **The first quarterly access review on the platform.** It takes hours instead of weeks. The conversation shifts from “IT tool” to “compliance infrastructure” and contract value steps up.
- 3 **HR asks for onboarding orchestration.** They want to add their side of onboarding to the same platform. A second budget line — HR’s — starts contributing to the same contract.
- 4 **The customer’s natural hiring growth.** More events flow through the platform. With event- or seat-based pricing, the contract expands with the customer’s growth, no new sales conversation needed.

A customer that lands at a modest contract for IT provisioning can grow that contract two to three times within 24 to 30 months as the platform expands into compliance reporting, HR orchestration, and software spend visibility. This isn’t a promise — it’s the path the product structure makes possible.

Why the whole strategy holds together

- The **segment** works because the IT pain is acute, the compliance trigger creates predictable demand, and the buying motion is fast enough for a first PM to close customers in months.
- The **opportunity** is real because the spend already exists, fragmented across multiple tools, and willingness to pay is proven by adjacent products.
- The **core problem** — the missing access graph — turns this from “another workflow tool” into “the system of record for the employee access lifecycle.”
- The **moats** are the direct consequence of owning the graph.

- The **expansion path** works because every adjacent module reads from data we already have, not data we need to go collect.

— Sources

Key data points referenced in this document, with their sources.

BetterCloud — 2025 State of SaaS Report. Average software applications per company by size (96 apps at 200–749 employees; 116 at 750–1,499); 48% of IT teams worry about missing offboarding steps; 1 IT professional now supports 108 employees on average.

Productiv — State of SaaS. 53% of software licenses go unused in the average company.

Sprinto. Indian compliance automation company; 1,000+ customers; ~\$32M raised. Used as the willingness-to-pay proof point. (sprinto.com)

IMARC Group. India HR technology market valued at ~\$1.12 billion in 2024, growing at high single-digit CAGR.

NASSCOM. India hosts over 1,760 Global Capability Centers employing ~1.9 million people.

Diginomica / company data. Darwinbox serves ~1,100 customers globally; typical customer in the 3,500–4,000 employee range — used to establish that incumbents are enterprise-focused.

Keka. Foundation plan from ~₹9,999/month for up to 100 employees — used to establish the low-cost incumbent floor in the sub-200 segment. (keka.com)

Company counts for the target segment and per-customer pain estimates are triangulated from the sourced figures above and presented as directional, not precise.